INTRODUCTION

THE distress of prisoners, of which there are few who have not some imperfect idea, came more immediately under my notice when I was sheriff of the county of Bedford; and the circumstance which excited me to activity in their behalf was, the seeing, some—who by the verdict of juries were declared not guilty; some—on whom the grand jury did not find such an appearance of guilt as subjected them to trial; and some—whose prosecutors did not appear against them;—after having been confined for months, dragged back to gaol, and locked up again till they should pay sundry fees to the gaoler, the clerk of assize, etc.

In order to redress this hardship, I applied to the justices of the county for a salary to the gaoler in lieu of his fees. The bench were properly affected with the grievance, and willing to grant the relief desired: but they wanted a precedent for charging the county with the expense. I therefore rode into several neighbouring counties in search of one; but I soon learned that the same injustice was practised in them; and looking into the prisons, I beheld scenes of calamity, which I grew daily more and more anxious to alleviate. In order therefore to gain a more perfect knowledge of the particulars and extent of it, by various and accurate observation, I visited most of the county gaols in England.

Seeing in two or three of them some poor creatures whose aspect was singularly deplorable, and asking the cause of it, the answer was, "they were lately brought from the bridewells." This started a fresh subject of inquiry. I resolved to inspect the bridewells: and for that purpose travelled again into the counties where I had been; and, indeed into all the rest; examining houses of correction, city and town gaols. I beheld in many of them, as well as in the county gaols, a complication of distress; but my attention was principally fixed by the gaol-fever and the smallpox, which I saw prevailing to the